



Vocabulary Madness (When you don't have time to prepare)

Tricky Lookalike Words

The following pairs of words look similar and are easily confused with each other. Test writers often take advantage of this confusion. Some are very similar in meaning, while others are different. Know the difference!

- 1) adulate and adulterate
- 2) adverse and averse
- 3) anachronism and anarchism
- 4) antipathy and apathy
- 5) ascetic and aesthetic
- 6) baleful and baneful



- 7) censure and censor
- 8) capitulate and recapitulate
- 9) disparate and desperate
- 10) divers and diverse
- 11) elicit and illicit
- 12) heterogeneous and homogeneous
- 13) illusion and allusion
- 14) imbibe and imbue
- 15) imminent and eminent
- 16) ingenious and ingenuous
- 17) mendicant and mendacious
- 18) penury and penurious
- 19) pestilence and petulance
- 20) qualitative and quantitative



21) vicious and viscious

1) **adulate**: to praise,
adulterate: to make impure

2) **adverse**: hostile;
averse: unwilling

3) **anachronism**: an outdated custom,
anarchism: disruptive

4) **antipathy**: hatred, aversion,
apathy: indifference

5) **ascetic**: self-denying, abstinent, austere
aesthetic: related to beauty or art

6) **baleful**: forshadows evil,
baneful: poisonous, deadly

7) **censure**: blame, criticize,
censor: to remove the inappropriate

8) **capitulate**: to surrender,
recapitulate: to repeat



9) **disparate**: different; diverse,
desperate: needy, beyond reason

10) **divers**: several
diverse: distinct, varied

11) **elicit**: to draw out, provoke
illicit: illegal, improper

12) **heterogeneous**: diverse throughout
homogeneous: the same throughout

13) **illusion**: something unreal deceptive
allusion: indirect reference

14) **imbibe**: to drink
imbue: to infuse, dye, wet or moisten

15) **imminent**: at any moment, soon
eminent: famous, renowned

16) **ingenious**: original, clever
ingenuous: straightforward, open

17) **mendicant**: beggar
mendacious: dishonest



18) **penury**: extreme poverty
penurious: stingy

19) **pestilence**: epidemic, plague
petulance: irritable or ill-tempered

20) **qualitative**: having to do with a quality,
quantitative: having to do with a number

21) **vicious**: mean;
viscious: resistance to flow

No Time to Memorize? Learn to Recognize Groups of Related Words

Many test questions simply require you to have a general idea of what a word means, not an exact definition. Use this list to quickly learn a few hundred related words that are grouped in commonly-tested subject areas.

1) **Communication**

assertion: a declaration or statement

clarity: clearness in communication



cogent: convincing, reasonable

coherent: logically connected

cohesive: sticking together

didactic: intended to instruct

discourse: verbal expression, conversation

eloquence: the ability to speak persuasively

fluid: flows easily

lucid: clearly understood

rhetoric: using language effectively and persuasively

2) Legal Terms

arbiter: a judge

exculpate: to free from guilt or blame

incontrovertible: indisputable



integrity: trustworthiness

jurisprudence: the philosophy or science of law

objectivity: treating facts without influence from personal feelings or biases

penitent: expressing remorse for misdeeds

vindicated: freed from blame

3) Air of Superiority

condescending: treating others as inferior

contemptuous: scornful

despotic: having absolute power, tyrannical

dictatorial: domineering, overbearing

disdain: contempt, scorn

imperious: domineering, overbearing

patronizing: to treat in a condescending manner



4) Hard to Understand

convoluted: intricate, complex

cryptic: difficult to comprehend

futile: pointless

impede: to slow progress

obscure: to conceal

quandary: a state of uncertainty

5) Bad Habits

dilatory: always late

indolent: lazy

insipid: uninteresting, unchallenging

listless: lacking energy

torpor: laziness, dullness



6) Excessive

ebullience: intense enthusiasm

effusive: emotionally unrestrained

egregious: bad or offensive

flagrant: shocking or noticeable

frenetic: wildly excited or active

gratuitous: given freely, unwarranted

superfluous: extra, unnecessary

7) Positive Connotations

asylum: a place for retreat

auspicious: favorable, promising

benevolent: well-meaning, generous

benign: kind and gentle



emollient: soft and soothing

intuition: sharp insight

mollify: to calm or soothe

reclamation: to make something useful again

sanction: to give official approval

8) Untruthful

dubious: doubtful

dogmatic: stubbornly adhering to unproven beliefs

fabricated: made, concocted to deceive

hypocrisy: insincerity

slander: false oral statements about someone

spurious: not genuine, counterfeit



9) Sneaky

astute: clever, shrewd

camouflage: to hide by blending in

clandestine: secretive

coup: a well-executed plan

disingenuous: not straightforward, crafty

ruse: a trick

stratagem: a clever trick used to deceive someone

surreptitious: done by secretive means

wary: on guard

wily: cunning

10) Undecided

ambiguous: open to more than one interpretation



ambivalent: uncertain, felling opposite feelings simultaneously

apathetic: showing little emotion

arbitrary: determined by impulse rather than reason

capricious: impulsive

equivocate: to avoid making a decision

inconsequential: unimportant

tenuous: shaky, unsure, weak whimsical:
unpredictable

11) Hard Working

assiduous: hard working

diligent: hard working

dogged: persevering

intrepid: courageous, fearless



maverick: independent

obdurate: stubborn, inflexible

obstinate: stubborn

proliferate: to grow or increase rapidly

tenacity: persistence

12) To Bring Together

assimilation: to absorb, to make similar

consensus: general agreement

incumbent: imposed as a duty

malleable: easily shaped or formed, easily influenced

subdue: to restrain or hold back

13) Personal Space



inherent: inborn, built in

innate: inborn, possessed at birth

inveterate: long established, deep rooted, habitual

omnipotent: all powerful

proximity: closeness

14) Moving

elusive: difficult to capture

emigrate: to leave one country and settle in another

transient: moving from one place to another

transitory: short-lived or temporary

15) Friendly

affable: friendly



amenable: agreeable

camaraderie: goodwill

candor: sincerity, openness

facetious: playfully humorous

16) Feeling Bad

impinge: hinder

lament: mourn

melancholy: sadness, depression

truncated: shortened, cut off

17) Writing

aesthetic: appreciation of beauty

anthology: a collection of literary pieces

dilettante: one with a superficial understanding of a field



eclectic: composed of a variety of sources or styles

excerpt: a selected part of a passage

genre: a category of art

medley: as assortment or mixture of musical pieces

parody: an artistic work that imitates the style of another work for comic effect

virtuoso: a skilled artist

18) Calmness

decorous: proper, good taste

equanimity: composure

propriety: appropriate behavior

prudent: using good judgment or common sense



serene: calm

staid: serious, unemotional

stoic: impassive, indifferent to pleasure or pain

19) Negative Thoughts

disparage: to belittle, to speak badly of

pejorative: to speak negatively of someone

plagiarism: to pass someone else's ideas or writing off as one's own

vilify: to make vicious statements about

20) Rude

brusque: abrupt

caustic: biting, sarcastic

feral: savage, untamed

fractious: quarrelsome, unruly



incorrigible: unable to be reformed

ingrate: ungrateful person

insolent: insulting in manner or speech

notorious: known widely in an unfavorable manner

pugnacious: combative, belligerent

reprehensible: worthy of blame

21) Evil

deleterious: injurious, having harmful effect

enmity: mutual hatred or ill-will

heinous: evil, abominable

malfeasance: wrongdoing, misconduct

malice: ill will

putrid: rotten



rancorous: hateful

22) Old

archaic: old-fashioned

hackneyed: trite, overused

medieval: old-fashioned

obsolete: no longer in use, old-fashioned

23) Boring

austere: without decoration, plain

mediocrity: average, low quality

mundane: ordinary, commonplace

ponderous: dull

prosaic: dull, unimaginative



sedentary: settled, not migratory

24) Bad Feelings

harbinger: something that indicates what is to come, a forerunner

ominous: menacing, threatening

timorous: timid, fearful of the future

trepidation: uncertainty, apprehension

25) New

innovative: introducing something new

naive: lacking sophistication

nascent: emerging

novice: a beginner

26) Earth



arid: a dry, rainless climate

conflagration: a widespread fire

nocturnal: occurring in the night

sonorous: producing a deep or full sound

27) Abundant

comprehensive: large in scope

copious: plentiful

permeated: spread or flowing throughout

pervasive: dispersed throughout

prodigious: enormous

replete: filled to capacity

28) Respect

exemplary: commendable, worthy of imitation



laudatory: giving praise

venerated: highly respected

facile: easy

fastidious: paying careful attention to detail,
hard to please

meticulous: careful and precise

pramatic: practical

solvent: able to pay one's debts

29) Scientific

abstract: not applied to actual objects

paradigm: an example or model

rational: logical, motivated by reason rather
than feelings

theoretical: lacking practical application



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